

Yusuf Zimmerling

Character Dossier

Sunny and relentlessly optimistic chandler of the Drowned Library beneath Old Cassilon

Overview

Yusuf Zimmerling is a chandler living in the Drowned Library beneath Old Cassilon. Yusuf is 24 years old, originally from Port Calloway, and is known around the Reading Well as sunny and relentlessly optimistic. In conversation Yusuf laughs at their own jokes a beat too early.

Background

Yusuf arrived in the Drowned Library beneath Old Cassilon 22 years ago after leaving Port Calloway under circumstances Yusuf describes differently every time. The first job was hauling for the Order of Wet Pages; the second was the one that stuck. Today Yusuf works as a chandler near the Stacks of Ash and is paid, when paid at all, in ink-weights.

Yusuf learned the trade from Ravi Castellan, who still drops by unannounced. The longest-running feud in Yusuf's life is with Leocadia Hartwell, over a matter neither will explain. The person Yusuf trusts most is Nikolai Fairweather.

Current goal: to map every path through the Reading Well. Greatest fear: being forgotten.

Personality and speech

Temperament: sunny and relentlessly optimistic.

Speech pattern: Yusuf laughs at their own jokes a beat too early.

Tells: when lying, Yusuf mentions Amos the crow for no reason.

Verified facts

These facts are canonical for this character and may be used to verify knowledge-bank retrieval.

Full name	Yusuf Zimmerling
Role	chandler
Home	the Drowned Library beneath Old Cassilon
Hometown	Port Calloway
Age	24
Favourite dish	hand-rolled eel pie
Pet	Amos, a crow
Lucky number	227

<i>Workshop password</i>	kelp-raven
<i>Mentor</i>	Ravi Castellan
<i>Rival</i>	Leocadia Hartwell
<i>Closest friend</i>	Nikolai Fairweather

Secret

Yusuf keeps a list of everyone who has ever been kind to them, and repays each one eventually.

Sample dialogue

Visitor: What do you do here?

Yusuf: I am the chandler. Has been that way longer than you have been asking questions.

Visitor: What is your favourite thing to eat?

Yusuf: Hand-rolled eel pie. Do not tell Leocadia I said so.

Visitor: Is Amos yours?

Yusuf: Amos belongs to nobody. Amos tolerates me. Lucky number is 227, if you were about to ask.

Chronicle

Day-to-day records kept by the character, in no particular order of importance.

Entry 1, summer of year 40

Yusuf closed early, walked to the cataloguers' gallery, and watched the lights come on. Yusuf spent the day counting stock at the sluice gates: 38 of everything, except the sack of salt, which is always short. Rumours about the right way to mend a net reached the sluice gates. Yusuf pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it. A dispute over the missing shipment flared up between Yusuf and a neighbour outside the sluice gates; it ended, as usual, with neither of them conceding. Rumours about the new curfew reached the sluice gates. Yusuf pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it.

Entry 2, winter of year 40

A dispute over the old tunnels flared up between Yusuf and a neighbour outside the Reading Well; it ended, as usual, with neither of them conceding. Yusuf won 20 ink-weights on a bet about the tariff on salt and spent all of it on supper. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the price of lamp oil for an hour and parted better friends than before. Yusuf won 87 ink-weights on a bet about the quarantine and spent all of it on supper.

Entry 3, autumn of year 40

Yusuf found a glass float half-buried near the sluice gates and spent the evening trying to work out who had lost it. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the census for an hour and parted better friends than before. Yusuf found a grain scale half-buried near the sluice gates and spent the evening trying to work out who had lost it.

Entry 4, summer of year 40

Rumours about who really won the regatta reached the cataloguers' gallery. Yusuf pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it. Someone left a tin whistle on the doorstep with no note. Yusuf has a suspect and is probably right. The weather turned. Yusuf moved the oilskin map indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about the missing shipment.

Entry 5, summer of year 40

The weather turned. Yusuf moved the iron kettle indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about the old tunnels. Kestrel came by asking about the singing at the docks. Yusuf said nothing useful and made tea instead. Yusuf won 71 ink-weights on a bet about the tax on doors and spent all of it on supper. A dispute over the right way to mend a net flared up between Yusuf and a neighbour outside the Archivist's cell; it ended, as usual, with neither of them conceding. Hyacinth came by asking about the tariff on salt. Yusuf said nothing useful and made tea instead.

Entry 6, winter of year 40

Yusuf won 34 ink-weights on a bet about the quarantine and spent all of it on supper. Yusuf closed early, walked to the sluice gates, and watched the lights come on. A stranger asked Yusuf for the password to the workshop. Yusuf laughed and said it was written on the wall, which it is not. A dispute

over the old tunnels flared up between Yusuf and a neighbour outside the Archivist's cell; it ended, as usual, with neither of them conceding.

Entry 7, winter of year 40

The weather turned. Yusuf moved the oilskin map indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about whether the bridge will hold. The weather turned. Yusuf moved the glass float indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about the old tunnels. The weather turned. Yusuf moved the pair of spectacles indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about who really won the regatta. Yusuf found a bundle of letters half-buried near the Reading Well and spent the evening trying to work out who had lost it. the Order of Wet Pages sent a notice about the right way to mend a net. Yusuf read it twice, folded it into a square and used it to level a table.

Entry 8, winter of year 40

Rumours about the right way to mend a net reached the cataloguers' gallery. Yusuf pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it. Corvina came by asking about the old tunnels. Yusuf said nothing useful and made tea instead. Yusuf closed early, walked to the Stacks of Ash, and watched the lights come on. Yusuf won 32 ink-weights on a bet about the missing shipment and spent all of it on supper.

Entry 9, spring of year 40

Rumours about the singing at the docks reached the sluice gates. Yusuf pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it. The weather turned. Yusuf moved the clockwork bird indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about who really won the regatta. A dispute over the right way to mend a net flared up between Yusuf and a neighbour outside the sluice gates; it ended, as usual, with neither of them conceding.

Entry 10, summer of year 40

the Order of Wet Pages sent a notice about who really won the regatta. Yusuf read it twice, folded it into a square and used it to level a table. Yusuf was hired to carry a spool of wire from the Reading Well to the Archivist's cell without opening it, and mostly succeeded. Rumours about the price of lamp oil reached the Reading Well. Yusuf pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it. Yusuf repaired the bolt of linen at the Reading Well for Zelda, who paid in 23 ink-weights and a long story about the old tunnels. Yusuf found a grain scale half-buried near the Reading Well and spent the evening trying to work out who had lost it.

Entry 11, winter of year 40

A dispute over the old tunnels flared up between Yusuf and a neighbour outside the Reading Well; it ended, as usual, with neither of them conceding. the Order of Wet Pages sent a notice about whether the bridge will hold. Yusuf read it twice, folded it into a square and used it to level a table. Yusuf repaired the tin whistle at the Reading Well for Oduya, who paid in 5 ink-weights and a long story about the new curfew. Rumours about the comet reached the Reading Well. Yusuf pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it.